Lady Macnaghten, who had brought her own supplies. Almost everyone else went hungry, ‘obliged to lie down on the bare snow, without either shelter, fire or food . . . The silence of the men betrayed their despair and torpor, not a voice being heard.’[28]

Lady Sale was luckier than most: though she had now lost all her possessions and had nothing to eat, she had given her bedding to her daughter’s ayah to ride upon, so unusually she and her household did have some covering that first night. A few others were lucky too: the irritable Dr Magrath for example found an empty dhooly to sleep in. But as now became clear, the Bengali sepoys had no idea how to cope in the snow, a sharp contrast to Mackenzie’s loyal Afghan jezailchis who showed how it could be done. ‘Their first step on reaching the [camping] ground was to clear a small space from the snow,’ recalled an impressed Eyre. ‘They then laid themselves down in a circle, closely packed together, with their feet meeting in the centre; all the warm clothing they could muster among them being spread equally over the whole. By these simple means sufficient animal warmth was generated to preserve them from being frost bitten; and Captain Mackenzie, who himself shared their homely bed, declared that he had felt scarcely any inconvenience from the cold.’[29]

Just how necessary such techniques were became clear the following morning. Many of the troops had simply frozen to death in the night. ‘I found lying close to my tent, stiff, cold, and quite dead, an old grey haired conductor named Macgregor, who, utterly exhausted, had lain down there silently to die,’ remembered George Lawrence.[30] Many sought out the reticent Scottish assistant surgeon of Shah Shuja’s Contingent, the thirty-year-old William Brydon. He had spent the night warmly wrapped in his sheepskin coat and now rushed around the camp at dawn, trying to encourage those still living to jump up and down and warm themselves up. ‘I called to the natives who had been lying near to me to get up,’ he wrote in his diary, ‘which only a few were able to do. Some of them actually laughed at me for urging them, and pointed to their feet, which looked like charred logs of wood. Poor fellows they were frostbitten, and had to be left behind.’[31]

The second day of the retreat proved even more chaotic than the first.